Project Shield Our Elders

Brevard County, Florida

Family scam safety

A guide for families and caregivers

Scams can happen to anyone. A shared plan helps your family check unexpected requests while keeping your loved one involved in decisions.

Make a plan together

- Choose a trusted person and a backup, save their phone numbers, and keep a paper copy near the phone. Agree to check unexpected requests for money before responding.
- With your loved one’s permission, help set up account alerts, unique passwords, and two-step sign-in. Discuss suspicious contacts calmly and include them in decisions.

Check family emergencies

- Choose a private phrase that is easy to remember and unrelated to public facts or account passwords. Keep it off social media and workshop forms.
- For an unexpected family emergency, ask for the phrase without hints, then call a saved family number. Verify even if the voice sounds familiar or the phrase is correct, and change the phrase if it is exposed.

If money or information was shared

- If money was sent, contact the bank, card issuer, or payment service as soon as possible and ask about stopping or reversing it. A refund is not guaranteed.
- After a password or code was shared, contact the account provider and change exposed or reused passwords on a safe device. If someone controlled the device, disconnect it from the internet and get trusted help to remove remote access and check for malware.
- Keep messages, receipts, screenshots, and a short timeline. IdentityTheft.gov provides help for identity misuse, while ReportFraud.ftc.gov and IC3.gov accept scam reports. Avoid anyone asking for payment to recover the money.